



MOAR!

DEVELOPER

Guerrilla Games

PUBLISHER

Sony Interactive

Entertainment

PLATFORM

PS4, PS5

PRICE

PS4 ₹3,999

PS5 ₹ 4,999

limiting, inventory management was a pain and taking down human enemies became a chore after some time. If you have seen the GDC talk 'Horizon Zero Dawn: A Game Design Postmortem' then you will know that the developers were aware of these issues.

So, it is natural that we have seen improvements here.

Let's start with human foes. They are as complex as taking down a machine. A lot of them have armour plates you need to take out before you can deliver the killing blow. The human foes also ride and control machines, mixing up the fight each time. When it comes to machines, they are more varied than the first game. Each group of machines has their own strengths and weaknesses that you must exploit, forcing you to not only change your tactics but also the arsenal you have. The diversity of machines is also well spread out throughout the map so each new area adds a new machine to the mix, offering something fresh for you to take down.

The new traversal mechanics like the Pullcaster that can get you out of a sticky spot and the Zelda inspired

glider to cover long distances are godsend.

Inventory management has changed too. You can carry a limited number of health regeneration berries and other resources, and once your inventory is full, all your resources are sent to your stash. You have access to

this stash at multiple points on the map which makes restocking a breeze.

Crafting and finding upgrade resources has also become simple. You can "create a job" which highlights the area of the map where you can find the resource for the weapon or outfit upgrade making it easier to track. If you need a specific machine part intact, you can highlight it on the machine and ensure you detach it from the machine before taking down the machine.

Last but not least is the upgrade and skills tree. There is an extensive skill tree that can be used to unlock new skills, upgrade some abilities and enhance some of the firepower at your disposal. Let's break it down. While there are familiar and new weapons at your disposal, each weapon now comes with a unique ability. This special fire is

unlocked in the skill tree. You also unlock 'valor' surges which give you some enhanced abilities. So, you can enhance stealth takedowns, increase the power of your weapons, or increase your resistance to damage, etc. these 'valor' surges are upgradable.

GRAPHICS

Horizon Forbidden West is playable in two modes - performance and resolution. While resolution lets you play the game in 4K, it limits the frame rate to 30FPS. The second mode reduces the resolution and gives you a 60FPS experience. While we did notice some lag and stutter in the game, these were tied to very specific sections. So even when the action gets intense on-screen, the game maintains its target 60fps 95% of the time. There are some game-breaking bugs we encountered like getting stuck behind an invisible wall or getting stuck looting a crate till we rebooted the game. They happened often enough to annoy us. The game also randomly crashed a few times.

With the annoyances out of the way, Horizon Forbidden West is a stunning looking game with vivid colours and punchy environments. The character model of Aloy looks a lot more detailed and has ever so slightly more realistic movements.

A special mention to the design of the machines you encounter. Each and every one of them has a unique design, stance, special ability and more. Their movement and the overall quality of animation is very good, especially the machine boss fights.

VERDICT

Horizon Forbidden West isn't without its issues. There are invisible walls you can get stuck behind and the game has glitched out on us on multiple occasions. But the package on offer can be defined as a sequel in the true sense of the word. There is a lot to do here which is optional and there is a lot to do without it feeling like bloatware. If the Witcher 3: Wild Hunt is our favourite open-world game ever, then Horizon Forbidden West is most definitely a very close second! *